

strengthening individual battle-grounds in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh while showcasing their togetherness at the odd press conference. The idea behind the Fourth Front is only to enable Lalu, Paswan and Mulayam seek bigger slices in the political power pie once the votes are counted. But that will be contingent on the three leaders' performance in the Lok Sabha elections. The entire exercise has just one meaning—a powerful political platform to let the three regional chieftains bargain hard with the UPA or the Third Front once the poll results are out. With Lalu and Paswan gradually dropping their pretensions and locking the Congress in no-holds-barred acrimony

Several Muslim leaders in the SP have revolted against the leadership while the ulemas and other religious leaders have vowed to oppose Mulayam and his candidates in all constituencies. Mulayam's repeated clarifications failed to douse the fire and, unlike in the past, when he took the electoral bull by the horns, the former Uttar Pradesh chief minister has been on the defensive this time.

In the 2004 polls, the SP had 35 MPs, its highest ever, of whom seven were Muslims. The party had contested in 68 seats while the BSP had fielded 80 candidates of whom only 19 won. What has struck a major blow to the SP is

the exit of nearly a dozen MPs, including senior leaders like Beni Prasad Verma, Raj Babbar, Salim Sherwani and Atiq Ahmed.

In the 2007 assembly elections, the BSP had 31 Muslim MLAs elected while the SP had only 20, an indication that



in Bihar and Mulayam already breathing fire against the grand old party, it is now almost clear that the Fourth Front will have no hesitation in joining the Third Front (minus the BSP of course), should such a situation arise after the elections.

Mulayam Singh Yadav embraced his 40-year-old political rival and former BJP leader Kalyan Singh with the aim of winning over his support base among the OBCs and thereby putting up a strong challenge to the BSP. But as soon as Mulayam joined hands with the former BJP chief minister who presided over the demolition of the Babri Masjid, the SP chief began to face the ire of Muslims.

THE TRIO'S HOPES CENTRE AROUND WINNING OVER 50 SEATS IN BIHAR AND UTTAR PRADESH

Ram Vilas Paswan
LJP

THE LJP LEADER WILL NOT THANK HIS
 BEFORE DITCHING HIS NEW-FOUND FRIENDS
 (PAW) ON ETHNOCENTRIC LIFELINE

4 MP's only in 2004, but
 for Paswan it is
 enough to be a kingmaker.

Lalu Prasad Yadav *RJD*

LALU'S SHRILL ANTI-CONGRESS TIRADE REFLECTS A DESPERATION BORN OUT OF A FEAR OF MUSLIM VOTES SLIPPING AWAY.

24 is the number of
 seats the RJD won
 in 2004 when it fought in
 alliance with the Congress.

the party's Muslim support base was cracking. Sensing the Muslim anger at Mulayam, Mayawati has played an aggressive Muslim card by fielding 17 Muslim candidates. The Uttar Pradesh chief minister and BSP chief has been unabashedly wooing them, even going to the extent of describing the mafia don-turned-politician Mukhtar Ansari, the BSP candidate from Varanasi, as "messiah of poor".

If the formation of the Fourth Front reflects anything, it is the desperation of the three leaders of the socialist parivar to cling on to each other in the hope that, united, they have a chance to grab a chunk of the 120 seats in two of India's largest states. Their hopes are centred around the Fourth Front winning 50 seats or more in which case they could be on top, dictating terms in the formation of the next government. Anything less will leave Lalu and Mulayam with no option but to take it lying down while Paswan can be expected to go with the highest bidder.

**With Amitabh Srivastava in Patna and
 Subhash Mishra in Lucknow**